Writing NPU quant kernels: SIMT vs PTO vs ASC

Code size and simulated performance of three tilelang vector frontends implementing one group-wise quantization algorithm.

- 22 kernel variants, each implemented in ASC, PTO and SIMT plus a PyTorch reference: 88 kernels, all passing `python -m harness.check`
- msprof-simulated VF cycles for all 66 NPU kernels
- tilelang 0.1.15, ptoas vmi 0.1.9, CANN 9.2.0-beta.2, SoC `Ascend950PR_9599`
- Single core, `T.Kernel(1)`. Only the `T.SimdVF` / `T.SimtVF` region differs between the three implementations of a variant; tiling, DMA and buffer allocation are identical.

tilelang frontend comparison

Group-wise quantization, in PyTorch:

```
grouped = x.float().view(m, k // group_size, group_size)
amax = grouped.abs().amax(dim=-1).clamp(min=E4M3_CLAMP_MIN)
sf = amax / E4M3_MAX
q = (grouped * (E4M3_MAX / amax).unsqueeze(-1)).view(m, k).to(torch.float8_e4m3fn)
```

frontend	abstraction level	smallest unit of data
ASC (`T.simd`, `S`)	named hardware instruction and distribution mode	one 64-lane vector register
PTO/VMI (`T.vmi`, `V`)	operation with width and segment count as arguments	one logical vector, any width
SIMT (`T.SimtVF`, `T.Parallel`)	per-element expression	one element, held by one thread

`T.SimdVF` / `T.SimtVF` regions range from **6 to 57 lines** across the 22 variants. msprof-simulated VF cycles for the same variant differ by **10-100x between the SIMT and the SIMD implementations**, and by up to 1.6x between the two SIMD frontends.

ASC vs PTO: fewer operations, comparable cycles

PTO expresses the same 22 kernels in **74% of ASC's vector operations** and **89% of its source lines**. Simulated cycles do not follow:

PTO relative to ASC	
vector operations written	74%
`T.SimdVF` source lines	89%
simulated VF cycles	**0.92x mean**, range 0.64x-1.13x

- PTO uses fewer cycles on **9 of 22** variants, more on 6, and is within 2% on 7
- On 4 of those 9 it writes *more* operations than ASC
- Operations written and cycles executed correlate at **Pearson r = -0.09** (n = 22): across this set, source size carries no information about cycle count

Both SIMD frontends are 3-100x faster than SIMT on every variant.

Benchmark setup (and caveats resolved)

Cycle measurement. Sum the `cycles` column of `core0.veccore0_instr_exe.csv` over rows whose `instr` is a VF launch (`VF` for SIMD, `VF_SIMT` for SIMT). The filter keys on `instr`, not `pipe`: every VF row sits on pipe `PUSHQ`, which `MOVEMASK` and `PUSH_PB` also use.

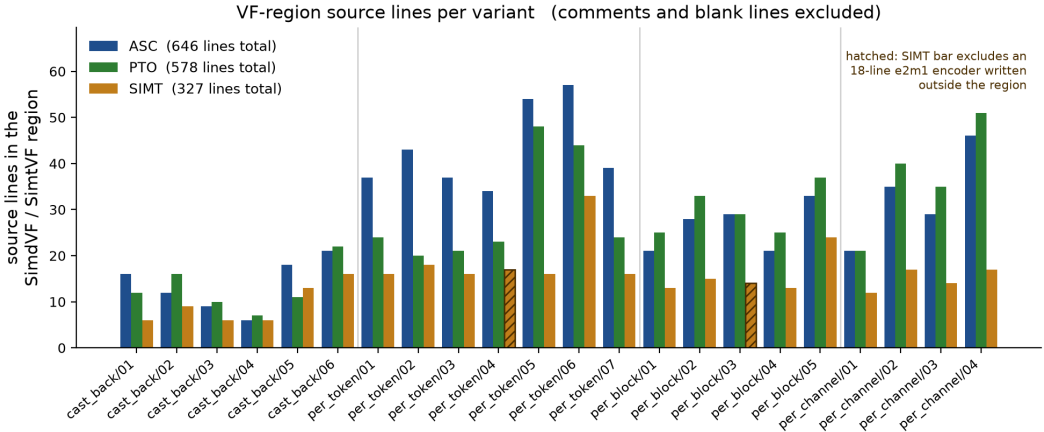
Correctness. Each kernel is compared against `harness/oracle.py`, with an assertion that the result was read back from the device. Cycles are not reported for a kernel that computed a wrong result.

Equal work. VF launch counts agree across the three frontends on every variant except `per_token/05` — ASC and PTO issue 34, SIMT 32, the difference being the gather index SIMT does not build.

Two measurement errors found and corrected. `per_token/06` and `per_block/05` allocated their input with `torch.zeros(device=...)`, an aten fill *kernel*; msprof profiles the first operator, so all three frontends had measured that fill. Both are now driven by `tools/vf_drive.py`, and `tools/vf_trace_audit.py` checks all 66 instruction logs for the arithmetic a quant kernel must contain.

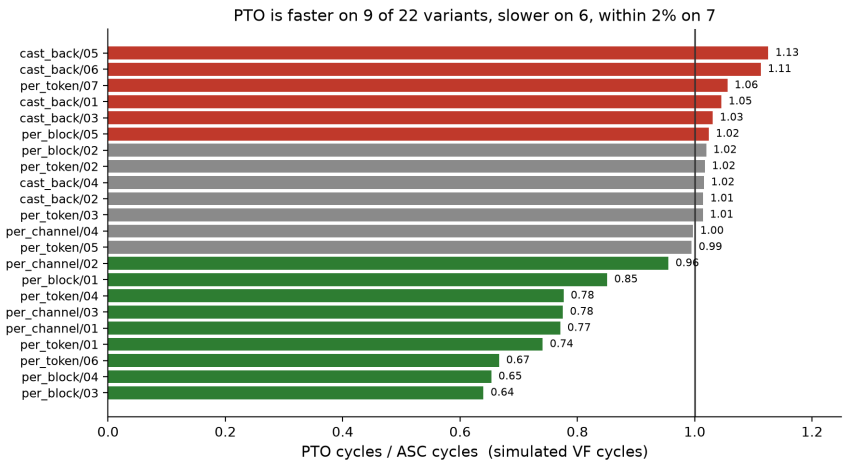
Reading the code fragments. Each is cut verbatim from a kernel the harness passes, and re-checked on every build. Within a variant the three fragments cover the same step; the SIMD fragments' enclosing `for ... in T.serial(...)` tile loop is elided and the SIMT fragment's `T.Parallel` header kept, because that header is what replaces it.

Source size: VF-region lines, all three frontends

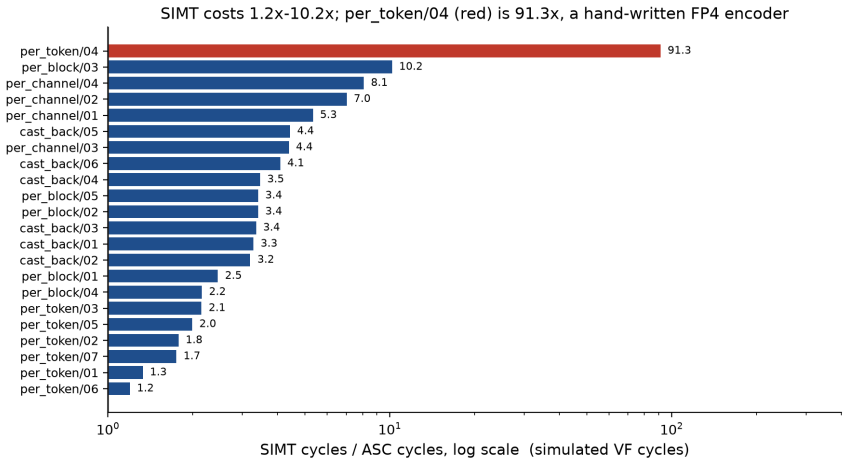


Totals **646 / 578 / 327** lines — PTO 89% of ASC, SIMT 51%. PTO is *longer* than ASC on 11 of the 22: its saving is concentrated in the segmented-reduction variants (A2) and spent again on `size=` and mask operands elsewhere (B3). SIMT is shorter on 21 of 22 and ties on the other.

PTO vs ASC: simulated cycles per variant



SIMT vs ASC: simulated cycles per variant



`per_token/04` is separated because its cost is a convert the SIMT surface cannot reach, not a property of the thread model (D1). The other 21 variants span 1.20x-10.18x.

Walkthrough: nine variants, four kinds of layout mismatch

The algorithm is the same in all 22 variants. What changes is where its quantities sit relative to the 64- or 128-lane vector register.

	variant	code pattern	what it decides
A reduce	`per_channel/01`	one channel per lane	nothing to simplify
	`per_token/01`	4 groups per register	PTO's clearest win
	`per_block/01`	32x32 tile to a scalar	one fold, not two levels
B scale	`cast_back/01`	one scalar across lanes	SIMT's first real cut
	`per_token/02`	exponent, any width	PTO's width argument
	`cast_back/02`	nothing to factor out	PTO's operands cost lines
C output	`per_channel/02`	interleave two registers	SIMT drops an instruction
	`per_token/05`	transposed store = gather	SIMT's biggest cut
D convert	`per_token/04`	float32 -> e2m1	SIMT's 91.3x

The other 13 variants compose these patterns and are measured in the tables at the end. Long form: companion report, sections 2-8.

A1 `per_channel/01`: the reduction axis is already the lane axis

One scale per channel: the reduction runs down the token axis, so a channel stays in one lane and no frontend performs a cross-lane operation.

ASC, accumulating across the 32 rows:

```
acc = S.alloc_local((1,), T.float32)
# seeding with the clamp floor makes the clamp free
acc[0] = S.vdup(E4M3_CLAMP_MIN, T.float32)
for row in T.serial(group_tokens):
    v = S.vabs(S.vcvt(S.vld(x_ub[row, col], dist="UNPK_B16"),
                      T.float32))
    # lane c holds the max over tokens seen so far
    acc[0] = S.vmax(acc[0], v)
S.vsts(sf_ub[col], S.vdiv(acc[0], qmax))
S.vsts(inv_ub[col], S.vdiv(qmax, acc[0]))
```

PTO — the same, with mask and width operands:

```
acc = V.alloc_local((1,), V.vreg(LANES, T.float32))
# seeding with the clamp floor makes the clamp free
acc[0] = V.vbrc(T.float32(E4M3_CLAMP_MIN), size=LANES)
for row in T.serial(group_tokens):
    v = V.vabs(V.vcvt(V.vload(x_ub[row, col], size=LANES),
                      "float32"), mask)
    # lane c holds the max over tokens seen so far
    acc[0] = V.vmax(acc[0], v, mask)
V.vstore(V.vdiv(acc[0], qmax, mask), sf_ub[col])
V.vstore(V.vdiv(qmax, acc[0], mask), inv_ub[col])
```

A1 per_channel/01: equal source, unequal cycles

SIMT gives one thread each channel and loops down the 32 rows — the tier's one scanned reduction (A2), because 128 channels already fill the region:

```
for c in T.Parallel(hidden):
    amax = T.alloc_var(T.float32)
    amax = E4M3_CLAMP_MIN
    for row in T.serial(group_tokens):
        amax = T.max(amax,
                     T.abs(T.Cast("float32", x_ub[row, c])))
    sf_ub[c] = amax / E4M3_MAX
    inv_ub[c] = E4M3_MAX / amax
```

measured	cycles ASC	cycles PTO	cycles SIMT	VF lines A/P/S
per_channel/01	502	387 (0.77x)	2,677 (5.33x)	21 / 21 / 12

17 and 16 vector operations, 21 lines each: segment counts and width arguments have nothing to apply to. Cycles differ anyway — 64 lanes against 128.

> ***A1*** *— where the data lines up with the lanes, PTO has nothing to factor out and SIMT nothing to remove. The 0.77x is register width, which no source count can see; it recurs, larger, at A3.*

A2 per_token/01: a segmented reduction is PTO's clearest win

Each 32-channel group needs its own maximum. An ASC vector reduction produces one value per register, so 4 groups require 4 masked reductions and 4 single-element stores:

```
a0 = S.vabs(S.vcvt(S.vld(x_ub[col], dist="UNPK_B16"), T.float32))
a1 = S.vabs(S.vcvt(S.vld(x_ub[col + LANES], dist="UNPK_B16"),
                   T.float32))
# Each register holds two groups, so reduce half at a time.
S.vsts(amax_ub[group], S.vcmax(a0, mask_low), dist="ONEPT_B32")
S.vsts(amax_ub[group + 1], S.vcmax(a0, mask_high),
       dist="ONEPT_B32")
S.vsts(amax_ub[group + 2], S.vcmax(a1, mask_low),
       dist="ONEPT_B32")
S.vsts(amax_ub[group + 3], S.vcmax(a1, mask_high),
       dist="ONEPT_B32")
```

PTO declares the segment count on one reduction:

```
x = V.vcvt(V.vload(x_ub[col], size=PAIR), "float32")
V.vstore(V.vcmax(V.vabs(x, mask), mask, group=groups_per_pair),
         amax_ub[group])
```

14 vector operations become 5. The matching broadcast on the apply pass collapses from 4 loads plus 2 selects to 1 load.

A2 `per_token/01`: SIMT, and the measured result

SIMT gives one thread each channel and asks the library for the fold:

```
for g, j in T.Parallel(num_groups, group_size):
    x_l[g, j] = T.Cast("float32", x_ub[g * group_size + j])
T.reduce_absmax(x_l, amax_l, dim=1)
```

The group is the fragment's fast axis, so the quant group *is* the reduction axis — the same reshape the CUDA reference makes before its own `T.reduce_absmax(dim=2)`. A clamp pass follows, since a fold cannot be seeded.

measured	cycles ASC	cycles PTO	cycles SIMT	VF lines A/P/S
`per_token/01`	6,176	4,576 (0.74x)	8,204 (1.33x)	37 / 24 / 16

Written instead as one thread per *group* with an inner `T.serial`, the same kernel costs 11.59x. The next slide measures that.

> ***A2*** *— the one pattern where PTO is both shorter and faster: 19 operations against ASC's 39 at 0.74x the cycles. Operation count and cycle count favour PTO together on 6 of the 22 variants. SIMT is shorter again (16 lines) at 1.33x.*

A2 per_token/01: the reduction spelling is worth 8.73x

This is the spelling the tier shipped first — a thread per quant group, the clamp riding along as the accumulator's seed, one line shorter:

```
for g in T.Parallel(num_groups):
    amax_l[g] = E4M3_CLAMP_MIN
    for j in T.serial(group_size):
        v = T.Cast("float32", x_ub[g * group_size + j])
        amax_l[g] = T.max(amax_l[g], T.abs(v))
```

`T.Parallel(num_groups)` has extent 4 at `K=128, group_size=32`, so it keeps 4 of the 128 declared threads busy and issues its inner body 32 times over. `harness/probe/simt_reduce_max.py` builds both spellings, checks both against the oracle, confirms they are byte-identical, and measures each:

reduction spelling	VF_SIMT cycles	vs ASC	instructions
one thread per group, inner `T.serial`	71,606	11.59x	36,676
`T.reduce_absmax` — what this tier ships	**8,204**	**1.33x**	**4,036**

The SIMT numbers in this deck are the library call's, in `per_token` and `per_block` alike; `per_channel` still scans, for the measured reason on the caveats slide. Nothing about the arithmetic changed — only the width of a `T.Parallel`.

A3 `per_block`: the same tile, half as many steps

One scalar per 32x32 tile. **ASC** takes 16 steps of 64 lanes:

```
for chunk in T.serial(num_chunks):
    v = S.vabs(S.vcvt(S.vld(flat_x[chunk * LANES],
                            dist="UNPK_B16"), T.float32))
    S.vsts(run_ub[chunk], S.vcmax(v, mask_all),
           dist="ONEPT_B32")
```

PTO reaches 128 float32 lanes, so the tile takes 8 steps of 128:

```
for chunk in T.serial(num_chunks):
    v = V.vabs(V.vcvt(V.vload(flat_x[chunk * LANES],
                              size=LANES), "float32"), mask)
    V.vstore(V.vcmax(v, mask, group=1), run_ub[chunk])
```

per_block	/01	/02	/03	/04	/05
operations, ASC -> PTO	21->22	27->30	28->26	21->22	29->31
cycles, PTO/ASC	**0.85x**	1.02x	**0.64x**	**0.65x**	1.02x

PTO writes more operations on 4 of these 5 and runs fewer cycles on 2 of those 4.

A3 per_block/01: SIMT has no tile loop, and folds in one call

A fragment's shape is an index space, so the 32x32 tile can be declared as a single row and reduced in one call — no steps, no partials:

```
for i, j in T.Parallel(bm, bk):
    flat_l[0, i * bk + j] = T.Cast("float32", x_ub[i, j])
T.reduce_absmax(flat_l, tile_l, dim=1)
```

What remains for one thread is three scalar operations, not a loop:

```
for _z in T.Parallel(1):
    tile = T.max(tile_l[0], E4M3_CLAMP_MIN)
    sf_ub[0] = tile / E4M3_MAX
    inv_ub[0] = E4M3_MAX / tile
```

measured	cycles ASC	cycles PTO	cycles SIMT	VF lines A/P/S
per_block/01	1,086	924 (0.85x)	2,664 (2.45x)	21 / 25 / 13

> ***A3*** *— more operations per step and half as many steps executed: a static count cannot observe a trip count. SIMT has neither, and needs neither: the two-level shape a GPU programmer writes first — a partial per row, then one thread folding 32 of them — measured 19,276 cycles against 2,664 here.*

B1 `cast_back/01`: broadcasting one scalar across a lane range

64 consecutive channels span two scale groups: each lane needs one of two scalars. **ASC** — two broadcast loads and a lane-mask select:

```
lo = S.vld(sf_ub[group], dist="BRC_B32")
hi = S.vld(sf_ub[group + 1], dist="BRC_B32")
scale = S.vsel(lo, hi, mask_low)

scaled = S.vmul(values, scale)
```

PTO — the segment structure declared on the load:

```
scale = V.vload(sf_ub[group], size=LANES, stride=1,
                dist_mode="brc", group=groups_per_strip)

scaled = V.vmul(values, scale, mask)
```

SIMT — an index expression:

```
for i in T.Parallel(hidden):
    o_l[i] = q_l[i] * sf_ub[i // group_size]
```

measured	cycles ASC	cycles PTO	cycles SIMT	VF lines A/P/S
`cast_back/01`	2,105	2,201 (1.05x)	6,908 (3.28x)	16 / 12 / 6

B1 cast_back/01: output dtype selection, and the result

The variant also switches output dtype. **ASC** picks a different store instruction; the wider dtype takes the simpler one:

```
if out_dtype == "bfloat16":
    S.vsts(out_ub[col], S.vcvt(scaled, T.bfloat16),
           dist="PK_B32")      # 64 lanes -> 64 x 2 bytes
else:
    S.vsts(out_ub[col], scaled,
           dist="NORM_B32")    # 64 lanes -> 64 x 4 bytes
```

PTO infers the packing from the destination buffer:

```
if out_dtype == "bfloat16":
    V.vstore(V.vcvt(scaled, "bfloat16"), out_ub[col])
else:
    V.vstore(scaled, out_ub[col])
```

SIMT emits no dtype branch at all: `T.copy` converts between buffers.

> ***B1*** *— SIMT's source is materially shorter for the first time (16 lines to 6): per-element indexing replaces explicit lane-mask construction, at 3.28x, the 10th lowest SIMT ratio of 22.*

B2 `per_token/02`: lane count as a parameter

The scale is rounded up to a power of two by rewriting the float32 exponent field. **ASC** fixes the lane count in every type name (`"uint32x64"`):

```
one = S.vdup(1, T.uint32)
bits = T.reinterpret(S.vmuls(clamped, inv_qmax), "uint32x64")
# ((bits - 1) >> 23) + 1  ==  ceil(log2(v)) + 127
biased = S.vadds(S.vshrs(S.vsub(bits, one), 23), 1)
sf = T.reinterpret(S.vshls(biased, 23), "float32x64")
# 254 - biased == 127 - ceil_exp: the negated exponent
inv = T.reinterpret(
    S.vshls(S.vsub(S.vdup(254, T.uint32), biased), 23),
    "float32x64")
```

PTO takes the width as an argument, so one `@T.macro` body — `compute_scale(amax, lanes)` — serves 4, 64, 128 or 256 lanes:

```
one = V.vbrc(T.uint32(1), size=lanes)
shift = V.vbrc(T.uint32(23), size=lanes)
bits = V.vinterpret_cast(
    V.vmul(clamped, V.vbrc(T.float32(inv_qmax), size=lanes), mask), "uint32")
# ((bits - 1) >> 23) + 1  ==  ceil(log2(v)) + 127
biased = V.vadd(V.vshr(V.vsub(bits, one), shift), one)
sf = V.vinterpret_cast(V.vshl(biased, shift), "float32")
# 254 - biased == 127 - ceil_exp: the negated exponent, still biased.
inv = V.vinterpret_cast(
    V.vshl(V.vsub(V.vbrc(T.uint32(254), size=lanes), biased), shift), "float32")
```

B2 `per_token/02`: the same arithmetic on scalars

SIMT has no vector width to carry. Its first six lines are A2's reduction unchanged; the scale arithmetic is the last four:

```
for g in T.Parallel(num_groups):
    amax = T.max(amax_l[g], E4M3_CLAMP_MIN)

    bits = T.reinterpret("int32", amax / E4M3_MAX)
    biased = ((bits - 1) >> 23) + 1
    sf_l[g] = T.reinterpret("float32", biased << 23)
    inv_l[g] = T.reinterpret("float32", (254 - biased) << 23)
```

measured	cycles ASC	cycles PTO	cycles SIMT	VF lines A/P/S
`per_token/02`	4,608	4,688 (1.02x)	8,197 (1.78x)	43 / 20 / 18

> ***B2*** *— 45 operations against 14 is the largest operation-count reduction in the set, at a 1.02x cycle ratio. PTO's gain here is a definition that is written once instead of per width; it is not a speed gain, and reporting only the operation count would have presented it as one.*

B3 `cast_back/02`: where PTO's explicitness costs source length

Decoding a UE8M0 exponent byte. **ASC** names the distribution mode:

```
packed = S.vld(sf_ub[strip], dist="BRC_B16")
bits = S.vand(S.vshl(T.reinterpret(packed, "uint32x64"),
                     sf_shift), exp_mask)
# An exponent field with a zero mantissa *is* 2^(e-127).
scale = T.reinterpret(bits, "float32x64")
```

PTO states width, stride, group count and mask:

```
packed = V.vload(sf_ub[strip], size=LANES * 2, stride=1,
                 dist_mode="brc", group=1)
bits = V.vand(V.vshl(V.vinterpret_cast(packed, "uint32"),
                     sf_shift), exp_mask)
scale = V.vinterpret_cast(bits, "float32")
```

SIMT shifts by a per-element amount, which VMI cannot express — `V.vshrs` takes a scalar:

```
for i in T.Parallel(hidden):
    g = i // group_size
    word = T.Cast("int32", sf_ub[g // PACK_FACTOR])
    byte = (word >> (8 * (g % PACK_FACTOR))) & 0xFF
    o_l[i] = q_l[i] * T.reinterpret("float32", byte << 23)
```

> ***B3*** *— the counter-example to B2. With nothing to factor out, operations tie at 12 and PTO runs 16 lines against 12; SIMT writes 9 at 3.20x, the tier's lowest.*

C1 per_channel/02: M-packed scales require a lane interleave

Output byte 2c holds m-group 2i's exponent for channel c, byte 2c+1 holds m-group 2i+1's. On a vector unit this is an interleave instruction.

ASC:

```
a = S.vld(sf_rows_ub[0, col], dist="NORM_B8")
b = S.vld(sf_rows_ub[1, col], dist="NORM_B8")
# A uint8 register is 256 lanes, so `lo` already holds the
# interleave of the first 128 elements of each input --
# exactly the 256 output bytes for these 128 channels.
# `hi` interleaves the padding and is discarded.
lo, _ = S.vintlv(a, b)
S.vsts(packed_ub[col * PACK_FACTOR], lo, dist="NORM_B8")
```

PTO — same instruction, with the vector width given explicitly:

```
a = V.vload(sf_rows_ub[0, col], size=BYTE_LANES * 2)
b = V.vload(sf_rows_ub[1, col], size=BYTE_LANES * 2)
# A uint8 register is 256 lanes, so `lo` already holds the
# interleave of the first 128 elements of each input --
# exactly the 256 output bytes for these 128 channels.
# `hi` interleaves the padding and is discarded.
lo, _ = V.vintlv(a, b, byte_mask)
V.vstore(lo, packed_ub[col * PACK_FACTOR])
```

C1 per_channel/02: SIMT replaces the interleave with two scalar stores

```
for c in T.Parallel(hidden):
    packed_ub[PACK_FACTOR * c] = sf_rows_ub[0, c]
    packed_ub[PACK_FACTOR * c + 1] = sf_rows_ub[1, c]
```

A uint8 vector register holds 256 lanes, so the loads above read 128 bytes past the 128 meaningful ones. Both SIMD frontends therefore pad the scratch buffer by a whole tile:

```
sf_rows_ub = T.alloc_shared((PACK_FACTOR, hidden + BYTE_LANES), T.uint8)
```

```
sf_rows_ub = T.alloc_shared((PACK_FACTOR, hidden + BYTE_LANES), T.uint8)
```

A scalar store cannot overrun, so SIMT allocates the exact size:

```
sf_rows_ub = T.alloc_shared((PACK_FACTOR, hidden), T.uint8)
```

C1 `per_channel/02`: the measured cost of removing the interleave

measured	cycles ASC	cycles PTO	cycles SIMT	VF lines A/P/S
`per_channel/02`	849	811 (0.96x)	5,964 (7.02x)	35 / 40 / 17

- SIMT removes one instruction and one padding requirement, using 17 lines against ASC's 35, at **7.02x** the cycles
- PTO is **5 lines longer** than ASC (40 vs 35) at 0.96x the cycles: the explicit `size=` and mask operands cost source length, not time

> ***C1*** *— SIMT's largest structural simplification so far: it deletes an instruction and a correctness rule about register width. Both deletions are real; 7.02x is what they cost.*

C2 `per_token/05`: column-major scales require a register gather

Lane assignment inside a vector register is fixed, so transposing the scale array means computing, per lane, which source element that lane receives.

ASC builds the index vector from the lane id:

```
lane = S.vci(0, T.int32)
token_of_lane = S.vand(T.reinterpret(lane, "uint32x64"),
                       S.vdup(token_block - 1, T.uint32))
group_of_lane = T.reinterpret(S.vshrs(lane, log2_block), "uint32x64")
S.vsts(idx_ub[0],
       S.vadd(S.vmuls(token_of_lane, SF_STRIDE), group_of_lane),
       dist="NORM_B32")
```

. . . and gathers through it:

```
S.vsts(sf_out_ub[base, 0],
       S.vgather2(sf_dense_ub[0, base], idx), dist="NORM_B32")
```

C2 per_token/05: PTO builds the same index; SIMT changes one store

PTO builds the same index vector. VMI has no scalar-operand `vmul`, so the stride is broadcast first — 10 lines against ASC's 7 — and the gather needs its mask:

```
lane = V.vci(T.int32(0), size=LANES)
mask64 = V.create_mask(LANES, size=LANES)
token_of_lane = V.vand(V.vinterpret_cast(lane, "uint32"),
                       V.vbrc(T.uint32(token_block - 1), size=LANES))
group_of_lane = V.vinterpret_cast(
    V.vshrs(lane, log2_block, mask64), "uint32")
# No scalar-operand vmul in VMI: the stride must be a vector.
stride_v = V.vbrc(T.uint32(SF_STRIDE), size=LANES)
V.vstore(V.vadd(V.vmul(token_of_lane, stride_v, mask64),
                group_of_lane), idx_ub[0])
```

```
V.vstore(V.vgather(sf_dense_ub[0, base], idx, gmask),
         sf_out_ub[base, 0])
```

C2 per_token/05: in SIMT the transpose is the store's index

The output buffer is declared with the axes already swapped — groups down, tokens across — while the input is read one token at a time:

```
# Already transposed: one column per token of the current block.
sf_out_ub = T.alloc_shared((num_groups, token_block), T.float32)
```

```
for g in T.Parallel(num_groups):
    amax = T.max(amax_l[g], E4M3_CLAMP_MIN)

    # ceil(log2(amax/448)) from the exponent field, then
    # both scales rebuilt by writing an exponent back.
    bits = T.reinterpret("int32", amax / E4M3_MAX)
    biased = ((bits - 1) >> 23) + 1
    inv_l[g] = T.reinterpret("float32", (254 - biased) << 23)
    # The whole column-major config: a different index.
    sf_out_ub[g, sub] = T.reinterpret("float32", biased << 23)
```

`sub` is the token index, from the `T.serial(token_block)` loop outside the region; `g` is the thread's group. The last line is the whole of the column-major configuration: `sf_out_ub[g, sub]` where the row-major variant writes `sf_l[g]`. Everything above it is B2's body, unchanged — there is no index vector, no gather, and no block of scales held back to be permuted.

C2 `per_token/05`: the largest source-size cut in the set

measured	cycles ASC	cycles PTO	cycles SIMT	VF lines A/P/S
`per_token/05`	5,477	5,448 (0.99x)	10,897 (1.99x)	54 / 48 / 16

- 16 SIMT lines against ASC's 54 is the largest source-size reduction among the 22 variants
- it costs 1.99x the cycles, the 5th lowest SIMT ratio of 22 — this row used to be the sharpest source-size / cycle *trade* in the deck, at 13.74x, before its reduction was re-spelled (A2)
- ASC and PTO are within 1% of each other: a gather is a single hardware operation, so VMI has no segment structure or width to collapse here

> ***C2*** *— one line of SIMT replaces nine of index arithmetic, and the SIMD frontends tie because the hardware already provides the operation. Where the work is index arithmetic, SIMT is the shortest by a wide margin and no longer pays much for it.*

D1 per_token/04: no FP4 convert is reachable from a SimtVF region

The hardware convert exists and all three frontends run on it. ASC and PTO name it — `S.vcvt(v, T.float4_e2m1fn)`, `V.vcvt(v, "float4_e2m1fn")` — so their work is limited to pre-rounding to bfloat16 with a sticky bit. Nothing in the SIMT surface reaches it: inside a `T.SimtVF` region the arithmetic is plain operators on scalars, and `T.copy` into an FP4 buffer does not compile (`harness/probe/simt_limits.py`).

ASC pairs two registers to deinterleave them, then converts:

```
low, high = S.vdintlv(T.reinterpret(q0, "uint16x128"),
                      T.reinterpret(q1, "uint16x128"))
odd = S.vor(high, S.vmin(low, one_u16))
S.vsts(q_ub[col],
       S.vcvt(T.reinterpret(odd, "bfloat16x128"),
              T.float4_e2m1fn), dist="PK4_B32")
```

PTO uses `V.vunzip`, which splits one value instead of pairing two. It is a `@T.macro`, so the call site is where ASC's three inline statements would be:

```
low, high = V.vunzip(x, "uint16")
one = V.vbrc(T.uint16(1), size=lanes)
return V.vinterpret_cast(V.vor(high, V.vmin(low, one)), "bfloat16")
```

```
odd = to_bf16_round_odd(q, PAIR)
V.vstore(V.vcvt(odd, "float4_e2m1fn", rounding="R"), q_ub[col])
```

D1 `per_token/04`: SIMT encodes e2m1 in software

So the SIMT kernel declares its output `uint8` and extracts the float32 fields by hand — the first 6 lines of an 18-line encoder covering sign, exponent, subnormal renormalization, guard/round/sticky and saturation:

```
bits = T.reinterpret("int32", v)
# bit 3 of (bits >> 28) is bit 31 of bits: the sign nibble, without
# depending on whether >> sign-extends.
sign_nib = (bits >> 28) & 0x8
exps = (bits >> 23) & 0xFF
mant = bits & 0x7FFFFF
```

measured	cycles ASC	cycles PTO	cycles SIMT	VF lines A/P/S
`per_token/04`	6,160	4,784 (0.78x)	562,280 (91.28x)	34 / 23 / 17

The result is bit-exact against the PyTorch reference packer. `per_block/03` carries the same encoder at 10.18x.

D1 per_token/04: 91.3x decomposes into instructions and divergence

factor	SIMT per_token/04	other SIMT per_token variants
instructions issued	243,130	4,036-5,828
of those, branches	44,835	0
of those, predicate sets	22,788	0

The second factor is branch divergence. `T.if_then_else` on a data-dependent per-element condition lowers to a branch rather than a predicated select, and this is the only variant whose trace carries a large number of `SIMT_BRANCH` and `SIMT_START_DVG` markers.

Rewriting the encoder's three conditionals as mask arithmetic (`m = -T.Cast("int32", cond)`, then `(a & m) | (b & ~m)`) issues **37% fewer instructions** and runs at **0.48x the cycles** — 269,370 against 562,280, or **43.7x ASC instead of 91.3x**. Both spellings are in the kernel behind a `branch_free` flag and the harness asserts their outputs are byte-identical.

> ***D1*** *— an instruction the frontend cannot name is not a style difference. Of the 91.3x, a factor of 2.09x is a code-generation gap a GPU compiler would not have, since it predicates such a conditional into a select; the rest is a software encoder standing in for one instruction.*

D1 per_token/04: the convert is reachable, from outside the region

`T.Cast` to FP4 cannot work inside the region: the chip has no scalar FP4 type, and the convert is a *vector* instruction over `vector_f4e2m1x2`. Nine spellings fail (`harness/probe/simt_fp4_convert.py`). The kernel can still leave the region for that one instruction:

```
with T.SimdVF():
    for pair in T.serial(hidden // PAIR):
        S.vsts(q_ub[pair * PAIR],
               S.vcvt(S.vld(bf_ub[pair * PAIR]),
                      T.float4_e2m1fn),
               dist="PK4_B32")
```

per_token/04, SIMT	cycles	vs ASC
the 18-line e2m1 encoder	562,280	91.3x
three lines of `T.SimdVF`	**7,778**	**1.26x**

72.3x, byte-identical, harness-verified; shipped behind `hw_convert=`, not the default.

> ***D1, continued*** — *"the frontend cannot name the instruction" is about the region, not the kernel. The thread model keeps the index arithmetic; the vector model keeps the one instruction that only exists as a vector.*

Measured data (1/2): `cast_back`, `per_token`

variant	ops A/P	lines A/P/S	cyc A	cyc P	cyc S	P/A	S/A
`cast_back/01`	9/7	16/12/6	2,105	2,201	6,908	1.05	3.28
`cast_back/02`	12/12	12/16/9	2,201	2,233	7,033	1.01	3.20
`cast_back/03`	8/6	9/10/6	2,080	2,144	6,969	1.03	3.35
`cast_back/04`	6/6	6/7/6	2,016	2,048	6,983	1.02	3.46
`cast_back/05`	16/8	18/11/13	2,296	2,584	10,152	1.13	4.42
`cast_back/06`	14/14	21/22/16	2,272	2,528	9,275	1.11	4.08
`per_token/01`	39/19	37/24/16	6,176	4,576	8,204	0.74	1.33
`per_token/02`	45/14	43/20/18	4,608	4,688	8,197	1.02	1.78
`per_token/03`	44/15	37/21/16	4,608	4,672	9,893	1.01	2.15
`per_token/04`	37/17	34/23/17	6,160	4,784	562,280	0.78	91.28
`per_token/05`	56/38	54/48/16	5,477	5,448	10,897	0.99	1.99
`per_token/06`	39/30	57/44/33	6,864	4,576	8,204	0.67	1.20
`per_token/07`	31/17	39/24/16	4,864	5,136	8,502	1.06	1.75

`/06 full` emits `/01`'s kernel, hence the identical SIMT cycle count.

Measured data (2/2): `per_block`, `per_channel`

variant	ops A/P	lines A/P/S	cyc A	cyc P	cyc S	P/A	S/A
`per_block/01`	21/22	21/25/13	1,086	924	2,664	0.85	2.45
`per_block/02`	27/30	28/33/15	918	936	3,130	1.02	3.41
`per_block/03`	28/26	29/29/14	1,625	1,040	16,536	0.64	10.18
`per_block/04`	21/22	21/25/13	1,414	924	3,044	0.65	2.15
`per_block/05`	29/31	33/37/24	918	940	3,130	1.02	3.41
`per_channel/01`	17/16	21/21/12	502	387	2,677	0.77	5.33
`per_channel/02`	28/29	35/40/17	849	811	5,964	0.96	7.02
`per_channel/03`	23/19	29/35/14	930	721	4,073	0.78	4.38
`per_channel/04`	32/33	46/51/17	738	736	5,964	1.00	8.08

`per_block` reduces a 32x32 tile to one scalar; `per_channel` reduces along the token axis. `per_block/02` and `/05`, and `per_channel/02` and `/04`, share SIMT cycle counts for the same reason: the composed variant emits the earlier variant's `T.SimtVF` region unchanged.

Totals across the 22 variants

	PTO vs ASC	SIMT vs ASC
vector operations	74%	not comparable
source lines	89%	**51%**
simulated cycles	**0.92x** (0.64x-1.13x)	3.73x (1.20x-10.18x)

SIMT has no comparable operation count: its arithmetic is plain operators, so the backend selects the instructions.

- PTO uses fewer cycles on 9 of 22 variants, more on 6, within 2% on 7
- The SIMT range excludes `per_token/04`; including it the maximum is 91.28x
- SIMT costs under 3x on 8 of 22 variants and over 10x on 2

Caveats

1. **Simulated cycles, not hardware.** `msprof op simulator`, SoC `Ascend950PR_9599`. No silicon measurement is claimed.
2. **One shape per variant**, mostly `M=32`, `K=128`. Ratios compare three implementations of one variant and are valid; absolute cycle counts are not comparable between variants.
3. **Single core.** No multi-core scheduling, double buffering or cache hints.
4. **The reductions are spelled for speed; nothing else is.** Every fold in `per_token` and `per_block` is `T.reduce_absmax` (A2, A3); `per_channel` scans, because its fold runs down the token axis where one thread per channel already uses all 128 threads — 1.06x, measured — and because on its two byte-packing variants the library call does not lower. The `cast_back` family is untuned, and so is the format work *inside the region* — D1 measures what leaving the region for one instruction is worth (72.29x on `per_token/04`), and the ladder does not take it. A separate SIMT-vs-SIMD suite sweeping several strategies per kernel measured 0.33x-53x, including SIMT faster on some grouped reductions.
5. **Line counts exclude helpers defined outside the VF region**, in all frontends. This understates SIMT by 18 lines on each of the two FP4 variants.

Caveat 6: the declared SIMT thread count

Every SIMT kernel declares `T.SimtVF(threads=128)`. At `K=128`, `group_size=32` the two passes inside the region have different extents:

```
for g in T.Parallel(num_groups):     extent 4    (the reduction)
for i in T.Parallel(hidden):         extent 128  (the apply)
```

Measured on `per_token/01`, the same kernel built at three declared widths (`harness/probe/simt_thread_count.py`, all three verified against the oracle):

threads	simulated cycles	vs 128	correct
32	8,911	1.09x	yes
64	**6,661**	**0.81x**	yes
128	8,204	1.00x	yes

It is worth 19%, and every kernel here declares 128. At `threads=64` this variant lands 1.08x ASC, 8% off. The same sweep on the serial-scan spelling the tier used to ship found all three widths within 4% of each other — the declared width only started to matter once the fold stopped wasting threads. Nothing in this deck is tuned on it: 128 throughout.

Conclusions

SIMT reduces source size where the SIMD frontends move data between lanes. A group broadcast (B1, 16 lines to 6), a lane interleave (C1, 35 to 17) and a register gather (C2, 54 to 16), costing 3.28x, 7.02x and 1.99x cycles — index arithmetic the thread model does not require, plus the 256-lane padding rule.

A `T.Parallel` must be as wide as its data, and that was most of the SIMT column. Handing each fold to `T.reduce_absmax` instead of one thread per quant group took `per_token/01` from 11.59x to 1.33x and `per_block/01` from 17.75x to 2.45x, output unchanged (A2, A3).

PTO simplifies where a segment count or a width replaces repetition (A2, B2: 39 operations to 19 and 45 to 14) **and costs source length where there is nothing to factor out** (B3: 4 lines longer at an identical operation count).

Neither SIMD frontend has anything to simplify where the operation already maps onto the hardware — a channel in one lane (A1), or a scalar scale (`per_block/01`): 17 operations against 16 and 21 lines each.

Where the hardware has an instruction, the frontend that can name it wins by a wide margin. All three run on the same unit; only ASC and PTO have a call reaching the e2m1 convert, and FP4 output (D1) costs SIMT 91.3x — 2.09x of it a code-generation gap (branch divergence), the remaining 43.7x a software encoder standing in for one instruction.

Frontend selection

SIMT — when the kernel is dominated by data placement (packing, transposes, gathers) and development time is worth more than cycles. It is never faster here: the shorter source is bought with cycles. *per_token/05 54 lines to 16 at 1.99x · per_channel/02 35 to 17 at 7.02x · cast_back/01 16 to 6 at 3.28x*

PTO/VMI — general production vector code, and anywhere a segment count or a width replaces repetition: 74% of ASC's operations at 0.92x of its cycles. *per_token/01 39 operations to 19 at 0.74x · per_token/02 45 to 14 at 1.02x · per_block/03 at 0.64x*

ASC — when an instruction VMI does not expose is required (per-lane variable right shift, which SIMT can also express — B3), when a distribution mode is the objective, or when there is nothing for VMI to factor out. *cast_back/02 12 lines against PTO's 16 · per_channel/04 46 against 51 · cast_back/05, PTO's worst cycle regression, 1.13x*

On methodology. Source size correlates with simulated cycles at r = -0.09 on this set: a frontend comparison reporting only source size reports one of the two quantities that matter.